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English 13

BAAP - AP1A

Theme: Gender and Identity

Topic: Gender influences political leadership

Gender: A Game Changer in Politics

Outline:

Introduction

Thesis Statement: Gender influences the leadership compass of politicians.

Body

- I. The similarities and differences on demeanor between male and female politicians.
 - A. Gender affects the decision making of political leaders.
 - B. Gender affects the emotion management of political leaders.
 - C. Gender affects the choice of words and manner of delivery of politicians.
- II. The similarities and differences on performance of leaders of different gender.
 - A. Gender influences the laws or policies to be implemented.
 - B. Gender influences projects created.
 - C. Gender influences the resolution of national dilemmas.
- III. The similarities and differences of men and women leaders when it comes to handling relations.
 - A. Gender affects the handling of international relations.
 - B. Gender affects the handling of local relations.

Conclusion

Background of the Study:

If we look back in history, most leaders were male. In the present time, presidential position are dominated by men across the globe. There are only few women leaders. For this reason, I want to scrutinize and thoroughly understand the underlying reasons why such phenomenon occurs. I want to figure out the various nuances of male presidents from the female ones. Therefore, I want to talk about the issue, how gender influences presidential leadership.

Statement of the Problem:

Gender affects politicians in terms of demeanor, performance, and handling relations.

Objectives:

At the end of this paper, I must be able to grasp the following:

1. Identify how gender affected the way how they think, decide, speak, and work.
2. Explain the similarities and differences on their performance in terms of laws and projects instigated as well as resolution of national dilemmas.
3. Understand how female presidents handle international and other relations from the male ones.

Significance of the Study:

Community

The information gathered and expounded will greatly help them critically decide and choose who are they going to vote during elections.

Future Researchers

The paper can serve as reference for future endeavors that could help in resolving national conflicts and at the same time contributes to the fountain of knowledge.

Politicians

Also, politicians will be aware of their actions and decisions reflected in the paper which can guide them in adjusting their interests and plans for the country.

Leaders grapple a huge responsibility when it comes to bringing its people to their fullest potential and self-contentment. They are the people accountable in bringing the country either nobility or destitution. That is why selecting a leader is crucial, beginning from the smallest social institution – family, up to the whole world at large.

Since the beginning of human existence, tribes were led by chieftains, and most of these chieftains were men. Until the time of civilization, political systems were practiced and the people liable for leadership were men and a few number of women. Meanwhile, during the era of global war, military leaders of state powerhouses like England, Germany, and United States of America were spearheaded by men and women. The names such as Adolf Hitler, Winston Churchill, Barbara Lauwers, and Princess Diana were few of the many people who had significant contributions in the making of world history. In the Philippines, Andres Bonifacio, Ferdinand Marcos, Corazon Aquino, and Gabriela Silang were remarkable for their excellent deeds that fueled progress and change in the country.

Both sexes have crucial and distinct expression of their political roles since time immemorial. Men and women leaders have their own way of doing their responsibilities, however, male politicians still dominates the political system today. As a matter of fact, there are only 20 out 175 nations across the globe who are led by women (Firstladies International, 2018). Therefore, gender forms distinction between masculine and feminine leadership in politics through demeanor, performance, and handling relationships.

Demeanor is one of the few things which makes an apparent distinction between leaders of different gender. The custom that men should be aggressive while the opposite sex is submissive is conspicuous in various nations worldwide. This socially constructed norm expresses the expectations on the manners of an individual at the same time discrimination of sexes. But, if we

look at it, this custom has its ancestral roots even before different Western civilizations touched the country. As depicted in the *Datu*-system leadership, tribal groups were led by men in war, resource management, and business, while women were for household chores and health care. Sadly, until today, aggression-submission behavior is still expected and seen for both sexes as more male politicians hold and run for positions in the government than women.

Since they are exposed to a variety of socially constructed behaviors and patterns, many male politicians act aggressively than the female ones. In terms of decision making, male politicians decide differently from the female politicians. According to Lewis, men are systematic thinkers while female are empathetic thinkers. Men most of the time rely on formulas, patterns, strategies, and systems in making decisions. Women, on the other hand, rely on their capability to feel with others. They use their emotional capacity to decide on different situations (as cited in Langan, 2011). Fortunately, based on my observation of the different presidents the country had, I believe that men are systematic and women are empathetic. I remember during the Gloria Macapagal-Arroyo (GMA) administration a women-led group, *Migrante International*, held the controversial issue about abuse and maltreatment of Overseas Filipino Workers (OFW) domestic helpers in different middle-eastern countries. They sympathized with the victims by calling the attention of Filipino and other nation leaders as well as agencies like the Philippine Overseas Labor Office (POLO) and Philippine embassies to look after OFWs abroad (Makilan, 2007). Meanwhile, President Rodrigo Duterte is different from GMA because he decides eagerly and implements immediately. Take for example his crusade against drug dispersion in the country. The moment he ran for presidency, he showed how serious and vocal he is about his advocacy to end the distribution of dangerous drugs. When he won the election, he immediately ordered the police to

operate the anti-drugs campaign or commonly known as *Oplan Tokhang*. Today, he still unequivocally campaigns the termination of drugs distribution and usage.

Aside from the fact that both gender differ from decisions, they also differ from managing emotions. As mentioned above, male are sympathetic beings and women are empathetic people. This provides a glimpse of how both sexes handle their emotion because being a leader is a difficult responsibility to accomplish. According to Goleman (2011) the empathetic view of women hugely affect the way how they manage their emotions during times of distress. Whereas men's systematic thinking influences their emotional management in such a way that they concentrate and remain composed. This happen because as public figures, they need to be courageous amidst the existence of social and political crises. If they show weakness, their people will lose confidence and trust in them. Similarly, this political expectation on leaders are rooted to their lineage. Even before the Spanish civilization invaded our land, wars between tribes happen. The dauntlessness of the *datu* is insufficient for he needs to have strategies and emotional resilience to win battles. He should not express doubts or fears before or during battle for it will dispirit his soldiers. The reason why men concentrate a lot and forget to see different perspectives during times like this is because the aftermath, either good or bad, would completely affect the country. I think President Duterte's criticisms on national predicaments is one example. He tries to generate solutions by totally focusing on the problem without understanding its root causes. He let his aggression take over him which affects his contemplation. On the other hand, female politicians are good emotion managers because they interpret the difficulty in different point-of-views (Thakrar, 2018). The approach of the former Department of Environment and Natural Resources (DENR) Secretary Gina Lopez on the issue about mining supports this. She believes that mining desolates natural resources and destroys habitats of various species. That is why when she knew that Roy Cimatu, the present

DENR secretary lifted the ban on mining, she was furious yet understands. She respected their perspective and scrutinized it by asking for valid reasons and evidence on why lift the ban on mining. (Alcober, 2017).

Furthermore, gender of politicians also impacts their diction and delivery of speeches. Speech is one of the most essential and basic power a politician has. His speaking prowess aids him to lead a nation and master the people. For this reason, words are indispensable in leading a country to progress and beyond. However, different people have different manners of expressing themselves according to their environment and usage especially when gender comes in. Haas (1979) states that men use language and words where they can easily voice out their message. They would not mind their audience as long as they deliver their sentiments. Meanwhile, female politicians use courteous and pleasant words to express themselves. They always consider the feelings of the audience whom they are interacting with. I also believe that most male politicians are forthright when it comes to their sentiments. They do not try to euphemize their spiels to please other people. Instead, they directly utter the things they want to say. President Duterte is an example of a politician who speaks directly what he wants from his colleagues and employees. He does not use decorative words to describe what he is feeling. On the other hand, the person who exudes the empathetic type of politician is Vice President Leni Robredo. She uses words which are pleasant and would not embarrass the person she is interacting with. This is because as a human rights lawyer and a woman, she knows how to empathize with other people. She understands how other people would feel if she express her insights in a negative manner.

Performance is the second ground which demarcates male from female politicians. Among all variables, performance is one of the most visible and tangible basis to evaluate a politician because it can be validated qualitatively and quantitatively through laws, projects, and solutions

drafted to solve political, economic crises. All humans have a different approach and perspective of life and it varies depending on the cultural, societal norms they subscribe to.

One most observable performance indicator of politicians are the laws they implement. As understood, human behavior is shaped by social and cultural hefts causing different genders to think dissimilarly. The same is true with how public policies or laws shape human behavior (Daniell, 2014). This implies that the physical environment where leaders grew up impacts the policies and programs they implement because they are influenced by the values and experiences they acquired. Hence, most laws formulated by politicians either male or female, are rooted to the principles and values they got from the environment where they lived and learned. Take for example Ferdinand Marcos, who was raised in an authoritarian parenting style of his father who was a military officer that time named Mariano Marcos (Campoamor, 2018). So, when he became the president of the Philippines, he reflected his father's parenting style to rule over the entire country - authoritarianism in the form of martial law.

In addition, projects and programs instigated are also one of the basis of performance for political leaders. Projects and programs of politicians, aside from laws, serve as building blocks of the reputation of the president and the nation. That is why it is imperative to develop and scrutinize the proposals of state leaders in the congress and senate about the programs to be implemented. Women in politics create programs which concern human welfare, education, and equality (Brettell & Sargent, 2001; Goetz, 2003); thus, support activities which promote protection and conservation of the environment (UN Women, 2017). While, male leaders develop programs which concern safety, security, and good governance. Likewise, I agree with what they said about the types of program leaders support and materialize. As known to be, women are more empathetic than men so their interest is focused on education and human welfare. Hence, Lewis argues that

professions which fit women are teachers, healthcare providers, and counselors because their strong emotion management can be honed and utilized properly. On the other hand, professions like engineering, computer, and mathematics are for men because their systematic view of the world is strongly employed in these professions (as cited in Langan, 2011). Therefore, women leaders generate programs which promote peace and unity among countrymen and male leaders sustain it by providing security. As an example, Senator Risa Hontiveros was the one who drafted the law about mental health. She strongly believe and support that mental health is as important as intellectual and physical dimensions of total well-being. While, *Oplan Tokhang*, of President Duterte exemplifies his aspiration of improving public safety by reducing crimes caused by people who use dangerous drugs.

Furthermore, response to national is a crucial performance indicator of leaders. The strategy they use portrays their effectivity and efficiency as a leader. For this reason, the strength of decision-making and emotion management will determine the success and resolution of the crisis. Winch (2015) argues that the emotional fortitude of politicians impact themselves holistically, particularly their leadership prowess. Emotional fortitude aids them to manage effectively, decide critically, think clearly, and cope efficiently. In the same way, I believe that strong emotional fortitude is an essential quality of politicians because it is normal for them to receive derisions from people, get stress with the economy, think of safety and security of the people – their concern is the welfare of your people. Female politicians differ from male politicians in solving conflicts in the approach and idea they utilize. The *Pantawid Pamilyang Pilipino Program* or 4Ps of the former president, Noynoy Aquino, is the program he employed to alleviate poverty. He immediately enforced it due to the exacerbating gap between the rich and the poor. Meanwhile, the economic recession of the Philippines due to the global financial crisis in 2008

during the time of GMA destroyed or worsen the economic condition of the country. In response to this swelling problem, GMA used her economical tactics to solve the problem by implementing the Value Added Tax economic policy on oil and power industries to keep the country afloat (Sy & Romero, 2008).

Lastly, men and women leaders, differ in the way how they manage their local and international relations. Men leaders are straightforward when it comes to their sentiments. They directly express their approval or disappointment and do not euphemize their language. The man who resembles this trait is President Duterte. From the very start, he is aggressive and impulsive with the decisions and steps he makes. However, when dealing with international constituents, he shows his respectful and serious aspect. Especially during the time when Filipinas suffered maltreatment in Kuwait and banned that country from receiving Filipina domestic helpers. He portrayed a formal and serious personality when he tried to negotiate the issue and by talking personally with the government of Kuwait (Placido, 2018). Women, on the other hand, are sensitive when it comes to their decisions and actions. They choose their words carefully and analyze who their audience are. During the economic recession, GMA carefully choose the words and sentences she will use to encourage the OFW domestic helpers to go back abroad and work. She persuaded them by comparing them to superheroes, calling them “*superindays*”. She handled the problem by talking to the international community who take OFW domestic helpers by drafting a memorandum which is beneficial for both parties.

All in all, gender influences leadership of both men and women. It creates the demarcation between the ways how both gender think and act alike or differently from each other starting from the variance in their demeanor up to the laws, projects, and relationships they establish. However, the biological make-up, social, cultural, and political values of a politician must be taken into

consideration because these things also affect their leadership compass. Nevertheless, the direction of our country depends on us citizens on who do we choose to guide us toward nobility. Now that you understand the common grounds and contexts which you can use to evaluate leaders, it is time to choose a leader who feels with the people, selfless enough to serve the people, and make this country a better place for humanity.

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